

A ROYAL TALE Aditi Rao Hydari, Naseeruddin Shah and Aashim Gulati in *Taj: Divided by Blood*

Aditi Rao Hydari didn't plan it so, but it is what it is. Audiences cannot escape her in 2023, as the actress features in not one but three web series on three different streaming platforms. It's a coincidence that they are all period pieces mounted on a big scale. In the first to release, *Taj: Divided by Blood* (ZEE5), she plays the iconic character of Anarkali, the cause of friction between Emperor Akbar (played by Naseeruddin Shah) and his son, Salim (played by Aashim Gulati). Thereafter, she plays a yesteryear Hindi film actress in the Vikramaditya Motwane-directed *Jubilee* (Amazon Prime Video), and a courtesan in Sanjay Leela Bhansali's much-awaited *Heeramandi* (Netflix).

Hydari has been exceptionally busy. When she sat down to promote *Taj* one morning in February, she had just wrapped up a late-night shoot for *Heeramandi*. Cribbing about her schedule, though, is out of the question. Hydari enjoys period fare, and it's not just a matter of chance that historical dramas come her way. With roots in nobility on both sides of the family in Hyderabad, Hydari's formative years were steeped in performing arts, or Hyderabadi *tehzeeb*, as she calls it. Her mother, Vidya, is a classical vocalist, while Hydari herself trained under renowned Bharatanatyam artist Leela Samson. She displayed her terpsichorean talent in only her second feature, *Sringaram* (2007), where she played a temple dancer and performed Bharatanatyam. "When you grow up surrounded by artists, music, dance, books and stories, it becomes such a part of your life that you don't see it as something different," she says. "As a curious kid, you just absorb from the people around you. It gets ingrained in you."

What *Taj: Divided by Blood* does differently is enable Aditi Rao Hydari **to see Anarkali as more than the tragic heroine** she has been portrayed as historically

As difficult it is to resist a project that takes her back to a bygone era, the final clincher for her is "always the director". And if they happen to be someone like Mani Ratnam (*Kaatru Veliyidai*, 2017) or Bhansali (*Padmaavat*, 2018) who keep her on her toes, then she's all the more happy. "You learn on their set: from how to handle your *dupatta* to how to hit your mark without it looking like you are. And you can go up and ask them whatever you want," she says. "It is so easy to become complacent and comfortable, especially when people think of you a certain way. Only good directors are able to challenge you."

The *Taj* series presented that opportunity for Hydari. Playing Anarkali, a role that's etched in the public imagination as one belonging to Madhubala and her alone, is no easy task. "I have happily absolved myself of all responsibility," says Hydari with a laugh. "No one can come close to the magic they created with *Mughal-e-Azam* [1960]. It is an iconic love story, it is untouchable." It helps that *Taj* is not a romantic tragedy but more a family tale with its own game-of-thrones drama un-